

Learn English in Seven

By Josef Essberger

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Preface

Ever since I discovered that $3 + 4 = 7$ I have always been obsessed by the magic number seven. It's a fascinating number, bigger than 5 and not quite 10. When rolling two standard six-sided dice, seven has the highest probability of being rolled. The word English has seven letters. In this light-hearted look at vocabulary and curiosities for English learners, everything is in handy bites of seven—an easy number to learn and remember.

Use the **power of seven** to help you learn practical English words, phrases, proverbs and more—anytime you have seven minutes to spare!

Good luck!

Josef Essberger, Founder
[EnglishClub.com](https://www.englishclub.com)

1: Seven Colours of the Rainbow

Have you ever seen a rainbow? Sometimes when the sun is shining and it is rainy somewhere at the same time, you can see a rainbow. It's a huge arch of colours in the sky. That arch is caused by the light from the sun being broken up by water droplets in the atmosphere. The sun's light is "white", but the water droplets break it up into **the seven colours of the rainbow**, always in this order:

RED

ORANGE

YELLOW

GREEN

BLUE

INDIGO

VIOLET

There is an easy way to remember them (a mnemonic):

- Richard Of York Gave Battle In Vain

These colours are the visible part of the sun's radiation. But there are many other parts that are not visible to the human eye. For example:

- immediately below red is "infraRED"
- immediately beyond violet is "ultraVIOLET" (UV)

[Learn more about colours](#)

2: Seven Prefixes

A **prefix** is placed at the beginning of a word to modify or change its meaning. Here are **seven common prefixes** in English, together with their basic meaning and some examples.

counter-

meaning: opposition, opposite direction

example: counter-attack, counteract

extra-

meaning: outside, beyond

example: extracurricular, extramarital

hemi-

meaning: half

example: hemisphere

inter-

meaning: between, among

example: interact, interchange

non-

meaning: absence, negation

example: non-smoker, nonsense

post-

meaning: after in time or order

example: postpone, postcolonial

re-

meaning: again

example: repaint, reappraise, reawake

[More prefixes with meanings and examples](#)

3: Seven British and American Spellings

Some British English (BrE) and American English (AmE) words have the same meaning and pronunciation but different spellings. If you are not sure about a spelling, it's best to look it up in a British or American dictionary as appropriate. Here are **seven common differences**, with examples.

1. **ogue/og**

BrE: analogue, catalogue, dialogue

AmE: analog, catalog, dialog

2. **our/or**

BrE: colour, favourite, honour

AmE: color, favorite, honor

3. **ence/ense**

BrE: defence, offence, pretence

AmE: defense, offense, pretense

4. **s/z**

BrE: analyse, criticise, organisation (but z is also used)

AmE: analyze, criticize, organization

5. **l/l**

BrE: enrolment, fulfil, skilful

AmE: enrollment, fulfill, skillful

6. **re/er**

BrE: centre, theatre, metre

AmE: center, theater, meter

7. **miscellaneous**

BrE: jewellery, programme, practise, pyjamas

AmE: jewelry, program, practice, pajamas

Note that in British English:

- “program” is used when talking about computers
- “practise” is a verb and “practice” is a noun

[Different meanings in British and American](#)

4: Seven Word Stress Questions

- a) How many syllables does each word have?
- b) Which syllable is stressed? (Capitalize the stressed syllable.)

Example: reality

Answer: a) 4 syllables b) re-AL-i-ty

- 1. quite
- 2. around
- 3. open
- 4. quiet
- 5. beginning
- 6. churches
- 7. television

Answers overleaf

Answers to 4

1. quite a) 1 syllable b) QUITE
2. around a) 2 syllables b) a-ROUND
3. open a) 2 syllables b) O-pen
4. quiet a) 2 syllables b) QUI-et
5. beginning a) 3 syllables b) be-GIN-ning
6. churches a) 2 syllables b) CHURCH-es
7. television a) 4 syllables b) TE-le-vi-sion or te-le-VI-sion

5: Seven Informal Contractions

WANNA know what GONNA means? LEMME show you.

Have you seen words like **gonna** or **wanna** and wondered what they mean? Perhaps you've looked in a dictionary and been unable to find them. That's because these words are informal contractions or short forms of other words that people use when speaking informally. They are not exactly slang, but they are a little like slang. In fact, if you look in a big dictionary, you will usually find them. Here are **seven common informal contractions**, with example sentences.

1. **gimme** = give me

Gimme your money.

Don't gimme that rubbish.

Can you gimme a hand?

2. **gonna** = going to

Nothing's gonna change my love for you.

I'm not gonna tell you.

What are you gonna do?

3a. **gotta** = (have) got a

I've gotta gun.

She hasn't gotta penny.

Have you gotta car?

3b. **gotta** = (have) got to

I gotta go now.

We haven't gotta do that.

Have they gotta work?

4. **init** = isn't it

That's smart, init?

Init strange?

5. **kinda** = kind of

She's kinda cute.

Are you kinda mad at me?

6. **lemme** = let me

Lemme go!

He didn't lemme see it.

7a. **wanna** = want to

I wanna go home.

I don't wanna go.

Do you wanna watch TV?

7b. **wanna** = want a

I wanna coffee.

I don't wanna thing from you.

Do you wanna beer?

Please remember that these are informal contractions. That means that we do not use them in "correct" speech, and we almost never use them in writing. We use them only when speaking fast and informally, for example with friends. Also, the sentences above may be a little artificial because when we use a contraction like "wanna", we probably also use other contractions in the same sentence, as follows:

Do you want a beer?

Do you wanna beer?

D'you wanna beer?

D'ya wanna beer?

Ya wanna beer?

Wanna beer?

Informal contractions with music

6: Seven Teens

What's a **teen**, or a **teenager**? People sometimes talk about teenagers when they really mean young people. For example, you might read: "This is a club for teenagers from 12 to 16."

Time to get accurate. Someone who is twelve years old is NOT a teenager. Someone who is thirTEEN years old is a teenager. How old is a teenager? A TEENager is between 13 and 19. Note **the seven teens**:

11 eleven

12 twelve

13 thirTEEN

14 fourTEEN

15 fifTEEN

16 sixTEEN

17 sevenTEEN

18 eighTEEN

19 nineTEEN

20 twenty

21 twenty-one

Note the following usage:

- They are in their teens. (They are aged 13 to 19.)
- They are in their late teens. (for example They are 17 to 19.)
- early teens
- mid teens
- a teen idol: an idol for teenagers
- a teenybopper: a young teenager (especially girl), who follows the latest fashions in music and clothes
- a preteen: a person aged 10 to 12

7: Seven Homophones

Many words in English have different spellings but the same sound. These words are called **homophones**. Here are seven homophone examples.

1. **sea, see**
2. **for, four**
3. **hear, here**
4. **one, won**
5. **knight, night**
6. **him, hymn**
7. **to, too, two**

What can we learn from all this? We can learn that the **sound** of a word is more important than the **spelling**. English is not "phonetic". That means that the spelling and the sound do not always match. Of course, it is good to spell correctly. But to help you understand spoken English and many rules of English, you should think first about the sound of the words. Don't worry too much at first about the spelling.

EnglishClub Wordchecker

knight (noun): in the Middle Ages an armoured soldier on horseback

hymn (noun): a religious song; a song to God

[Play these online homophone games](#)

8: Seven Category Questions

Can you match the seven WORDS in the top list with the **seven CATEGORIES** in the bottom list?

WORDS

leopard

desk

office block

v.a.t.

euro

accountant

cabbage

CATEGORIES

vegetable

currency

animal

profession

furniture

tax

building

Answers overleaf

Answers to 8

a leopard is a kind of animal

a desk is a kind of furniture

an office block is a kind of building

v.a.t. is a kind of tax

the euro is a kind of currency

an accountant is a kind of profession

a cabbage is a kind of vegetable

9: Seven Ways to Say "ough"

It's a pity that English is not phonetic! In some languages, you can look at a word and know immediately how to pronounce it. But in English you need to be a little more careful. Take the letters **ough**, for example. They occur in many words, but they do not always sound the same:

1. **though** (like o in go)
2. **through** (like oo in too)
3. **cough** (like off in offer)
4. **rough** (like uff in suffer)
5. **plough** (like ow in flower)
6. **ought** (like aw in saw)
7. **borough** (like a in above)

So how do you know the pronunciation of a word? Well, fortunately "ough" is an extreme example. English words are not always that difficult. But in general, when you learn a new word, you should also make sure you know its pronunciation. If you do not have a teacher or someone to say the word for you, you can look in a dictionary. All good dictionaries give the pronunciation for each word, often with special symbols. So it's a good idea to look at your dictionary carefully and learn the pronunciation symbols. After that, you'll always be able to find the pronunciation of any word, easily. Try it with the seven "ough" words above.

10: Seven Thats

The following sentence contains **seven identical words in a row** and still makes sense:

- It is true for all **that that that that that that that** refers to is not the same that that that that refers to.

(It is true for all that, that that "that" which that "that" refers to is not the same "that" which that "that" refers to.)

A sentence with a similar pattern, which may help to unravel the above, is:

It is true, despite everything you say, that this word which this word refers to is not the same word which this word refers to.

Or, if you insist on being really correct:

It is true, despite everything you say, that this word to which this word refers is not the same word to which this word refers.

11: Seven Continents

There are seven continents. The word continent comes from the Latin *terra continens*, meaning continuous land. Like countries, continents are proper nouns. That means they are names and the first letter must be a CAPITAL letter. Even for the adjective, the first letter is always a capital.

Continent: **Africa**
Adjective: African
Person: an African

Continent: **Asia**
Adjective: Asian
Person: an Asian

Continent: **Australia**
Adjective: Australian
Person: an Australian

Continent: **Europe**
Adjective: European
Person: a European

Continent: **North America**
Adjective: North American
Person: a North American

Continent: **South America**
Adjective: South American
Person: a South American

Continent: **Antarctica**
Adjective: Antarctic
Person: -

Strangely, we have a word for somebody who comes from the planet Mars (a Martian), but there is no word for somebody who comes from Antarctica!

NB: The English-speaking countries mostly teach the seven-continent model. However, six-, five- and four-continent models are also taught in some countries.

[More about continents and countries](#)

12: Seven Aches

You probably know the word **ache**. It can be a verb or a noun, and means to "hurt" or a "pain".

We sometimes combine the word ache with parts of the body. For example, if our back hurts, we say that we have "backache" or "a backache". We don't do this with all parts of the body. For example, we cannot say that we have a "handache".

There are really only five parts of the body that we combine with ache. They are shown below, plus two other words that we use in a slightly different way.

backache

earache

headache

stomachache

toothache

heartache

We don't use this to mean a physical pain in the heart. Instead, it means an emotional pain.

faceache

British English. This means an ugly or miserable-looking person.

13: Seven Funny Questions

A laugh-a-day keeps the doctor away! Jokes make us laugh, but they can also help us understand a language. Here are **seven jokes** that I hope you'll enjoy.

1. What word begins with "e", ends with "e", and has one letter?
2. I have 12 legs, 12 arms and 8 heads. What am I?
3. Which month has 28 days?
4. What starts with "P", ends with "E", and has millions of letters?
5. Why shouldn't you put the letter "M" into the refrigerator?
6. What animal can jump higher than a house?
7. Why can't a man living in Paris be buried in the South of France?

Answers overleaf

Answers to 13

1. envelope
2. a liar
3. all of them
4. post office
5. because it turns "ice" into "Mice"
6. a house can't jump!
7. because he's still living

14: Seven Units of Time

Here are **seven units that we use to measure time** and use every day (with their normal abbreviation in brackets):

second (sec)—There are 60 seconds in one minute.

minute (min)—There are 60 minutes in one hour.

hour (hr)—There are 24 hours in one day.

day—This is the period of time from sunrise to sunrise (equivalent to twenty-four hours).

week (wk)—There are 7 days in one week.

month (mth)—There are 28, 30 or 31 days in one month.

year (yr)

There are 365 days in one year.*

There are 52 weeks in one year.

There are 12 months in one year.

* Every 4 years there are 366 days in the year (the so-called “leap year”).

Note that people often use the following terms:

“24 hours” to mean one day

“48 hours” to mean two days

“72 hours” to mean three days

15: Seven Times of the Day

Here are **seven important times or parts of the day** in English.

midnight—This is the middle of the night (00:00 hours).

midday—This is the middle of the day, also called “noon” (12:00 hours).

morning—This is the time from midnight to midday (00:00—12:00 hours).

afternoon—This is the time from midday (noon) to evening. From 12:00 hours to approximately 18:00 hours.

evening—This is the time from the end of the afternoon to midnight. From approximately 18:00 hours to 00:00 hours.

dawn—This is the time when the sun rises or comes up (sunrise).

dusk—This is the time when the sun sets or goes down (sunset).

[Image showing times of the day and night](#)

16: Seven Meals of the Day

Do you know all the words for the meals that we eat during the day? Most people probably eat about three main meals every day, but here are **seven words for main and other meals** that we often use.

breakfast—The first meal of the day. Usually around 6am-9am.

brunch—A meal eaten in the late morning, instead of BReakfast and LUNCH. (informal)

elevenses—A snack (for example, biscuits and coffee). Around 11am. (BrE, informal)

lunch—A meal in the middle of the day. Usually around noon or 1pm.

tea—A light afternoon meal of sandwiches, cakes etc, with a drink of tea. Around 4pm. It is also sometimes called afternoon tea (mainly BrE). The word tea can also refer to a cooked evening meal, around 6pm (BrE).

supper—A light or informal evening meal. Around 6pm-7pm.

dinner—The main meal of the day, eaten either in the middle of the day or in the evening. Usually when people say "dinner", they mean an evening meal, around 7-9pm.

17: Seven Days of the Week

Everybody knows that **there are seven days of the week**. But do you know that there are only five weekdays? And of course the weekend has two days. Here are the seven days of the week. Note that the first letter of each day is always a CAPITAL.

Monday

Tuesday

Wednesday

Thursday

Friday

Saturday

Sunday

Now note that we call five of those days “weekdays”. They are:

- Monday, Tuesday, Wednesday, Thursday, Friday

The the other two days make the “weekend”:

- Saturday, Sunday

All of these days are usually abbreviated as follows (the most common abbreviations being the ones with 3 letters):

Mo., Mon.

Tu., Tue., Tues.

We., Wed.

Th., Thu., Thur., Thurs.

Fr., Fri.

Sa., Sat.

Su., Sun.

[More about days of the week and months of the year](#)

18: Seven -ed Pronunciation Questions

Everybody knows that the past tense of all regular verbs ends in **-ed**. That's easy :) But do you know there are THREE different ways to say the -ed?

Write /t/, /d/ or /Id/ after each of these -ed verbs:

Example: worked

Answer: worked /t/

1. played
2. added
3. delivered
4. wanted
5. washed
6. landed
7. liked

Answers overleaf

Answers to 18

1. played /d/
2. added /Id/
3. delivered /d/
4. wanted /Id/
5. washed /t/
6. landed /Id/
7. liked /t/

19: Seven Units of Length (Metric)

There are two systems of measurement in the English-speaking world: the newer metric system and the older imperial/US system. Here are **seven units of length using the metric system**.

These are the most common units that we use day by day:

millimetre (mm)—There are 1,000 millimetres in one metre

centimetre (cm)—There are 100 centimetres in one metre

metre (m)—The distance travelled by light (in a vacuum) in $1/299,792,458$ of a second, or, put another way, the length of about three human feet (with shoes on). Approximately equal to one imperial yard.

kilometre (km)—There are 1,000 metres in one kilometre.

Metre is the standard spelling in most English-speaking countries. In the USA and the Philippines the standard spelling is *meter*.

These are three other less commonly used metric units of length:

micrometre *commonly known as micron* (μm)—There are 1,000,000 micrometers in one metre. (The thickness of paper is approximately $100\mu\text{m}$.)

decametre (dam, dam)—There are 10 metres in one decametre. (Typically used by meteorologists in relation to altitude.)

hectometre (hm)—There are 100 metres in one hectometre. (A square hectometre or $100\text{hm} \times 100\text{hm}$ is equivalent to a hectare, a commonly used measure of area.)

20: Seven Units of Length (Imperial/US)

There are two systems of measurement in the English-speaking world: the newer metric system and the older imperial/US system. Here are **seven units of length using the imperial/US system**.

These are the most common units that we use day by day:

inch (in or ")—There are 12 inches in one foot and 36 inches in one yard.

foot (ft or ')—There are three feet in one yard.

yard (yd)—Approximately equal to a person's step, or a person's outstretched arm from nose to fingertip, or one metric metre.

mile (m, mi)—There are 1,760 yards in one mile.

These are three other less commonly used imperial units of length:

thou *also mil*—There are 1,000 thou in one inch. (Typically used in engineering.)

fathom (ftm) (depth)—There are 6 feet in one fathom. (Mainly used to measure the depth of water.)

furlong (fur)— 220 yards. (Archaic. Mainly used in horse racing.)

21: Seven Roman Numerals

You know that $2 + 2 = 4$. But do you know that $v - ii = iii$?

The numbers that we normally use in English (1, 2, 3 etc) are called "Arabic numerals". But we sometimes use another system for writing numbers — "Roman numerals". The Romans used letters of the alphabet to represent numbers, and even today you will occasionally see this system used for page numbers in books, clock faces, dates of movies etc. **There are seven letters used for Roman numerals:**

I = 1

V = 5

X = 10

L = 50

C = 100

D = 500

M = 1000

In general, letters are placed in decreasing order of value, for example XVI = 16. Letters can be repeated one or two times to increase value, for example XX = 20, XXX = 30. Letters cannot be repeated three times, so ~~XXXX~~ is not used for 40. In this case, XL = 40 (50 minus 10).

Here are two examples of the use of Roman numerals:

- The Introduction is on page vii.
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[Roman/Arabic numerals 1-1000 with converter](#)

22: Seven Odd-Word-Out Questions

Can you find the **odd word out** in each group?

Example: car bus train carrot plane ship bicycle

answer: CARROT—because all the others are forms of transport

1. cat monkey elephant wallet snake leopard antelope
2. beef rice watch pork lamb cabbage potato
3. road track canal corridor lighter way passage
4. book newspaper television internet radio film curtain
5. lawn town village hamlet city metropolis community
6. eye finger toe hair nostril knee leaf
7. museum bedroom cafe restaurant cinema gallery shop

Answers overleaf

Answers to 22

1. cat monkey elephant WALLET snake leopard antelope—the others are animals
2. beef rice WATCH pork lamb cabbage potato—the others are food
3. road track canal corridor LIGHTER way passage—the others are for movement
4. book newspaper television internet radio film CURTAIN—the others are media
5. LAWN town village hamlet city metropolis community—the others are living areas
6. eye finger toe hair nostril knee LEAF—the others are parts of the body
7. museum BEDROOM cafe restaurant cinema gallery shop—the others are public areas

23: Seven Units of Weight (Metric)

There are two systems of measurement in the English-speaking world: the newer metric system and the older imperial/US system. Here are **seven units of weight using the metric system**.

These are the most common units that we use day by day:

milligram (mg)—There are 1,000 milligrams in one gram.

gram (g)—There are 1,000 grams in one kilogram.

kilogram (kg)—The weight of a special cylinder of platinum-iridium alloy kept under lock and key by the International Bureau of Weights and Measures near Paris. Approximately the weight of a bottle of wine or 2.2 imperial pounds.

tonne *also* **metric ton**—There are 1,000 kilograms in one tonne.

These are three other less commonly used metric units of weight:

centigram (cg)—There are one hundred centigrams in one gram. (Used mainly in the laboratory.)

decigram (dg)—There are ten decigrams in one gram. (Typically used in medicine and pharmacology.)

megatonne *also* **metric megaton** (Mt)—There are one million tonnes in one megatonne. (Used mainly in reference to nuclear explosions.)

24: Seven Units of Weight (Imperial/US)

There are two systems of measurement in the English-speaking world: the newer metric system and the older imperial/US system. Here are **seven units of weight using the imperial/US system**.

ounce (oz)—There are 16 ounces in one pound.

pound (lb)—The basic unit of imperial weight. Approximately the weight of a football. The pound originated in the Roman *libra* (hence the abbreviation lb).

stone (st) (not used in USA)—There are 14 pounds in one stone.

hundredweight (cwt) *also long hundredweight* (mainly UK)—There are 112 pounds in one long hundredweight.

hundredweight (cwt) *also short hundredweight* (mainly USA)—There are 100 pounds in one short hundredweight.

ton (t) *also long ton* (mainly UK)—There are 2,240 pounds in one long ton.

ton (t, tn) *also short ton* (mainly USA)—There are 2,000 pounds in one short ton.

25: Seven Currencies

Most countries use a basic monetary unit (example: dollar) divided into one hundred fractional units (example: cents). Here are **seven of the world's major currencies** in English, with their currency codes and fractional units.

American Dollar (USD or \$, United States)—1 dollar = 100 cents

European Union Euro (EUR or €, most EU states)—1 euro = 100 cents

Japanese Yen (JPY or ¥, Japan)—1 yen = 100 sen (not used today)

British Pound (GBP or £, United Kingdom)—1 pound = 100 pence

Australian Dollar (AUD, Australia)—1 dollar = 100 cents

Swiss Franc (CHF, Switzerland)—1 franc = 100 centimes

Chinese Yuan Renmibi (CNY, China)—1 yuan = 10 fen

[Longer list of world currencies](#)

26: Seven 7 Questions

Can you name the following in English?

The seven colours of the rainbow

The seven continents

The seven days of the week

The seven Roman numerals

The Seven Seas

The seven teens

The seven extraterrestrial planets

Answers overleaf

Answers to 25

The seven colours of the rainbow—red, orange, yellow, green, blue, indigo, violet

The seven continents—Africa, Asia, Australia, Europe, N. America, S. America, Antarctica

The seven days of the week—Mon, Tue, Wed, Thu, Fri, Sat, Sun

The seven roman numerals—I, V, X, L, C, D, M

The Seven Seas—Arctic Ocean, Antarctic Ocean, Indian Ocean, N. Pacific Ocean, S. Pacific Ocean, N. Atlantic Ocean, S. Atlantic Ocean

The seven teens—thirteen, fourteen, fifteen, sixteen, seventeen, eighteen, nineteen

The seven extraterrestrial planets—Mercury, Venus, Mars, Jupiter, Saturn, Uranus, Neptune

27: Seven Seas

A very famous phrase in English is **the seven seas**. Many songs and poems refer to "sailing the seven seas" to express the idea of roaming the whole world by sea.

But what are the seven seas? Today, the seven seas are generally considered to be:

The Arctic Ocean

The Antarctic Ocean

The Indian Ocean

The North Pacific Ocean

The South Pacific Ocean

The North Atlantic Ocean

The South Atlantic Ocean

So why are the seven seas in fact oceans? Well, ocean simply means a very large sea. There are many seas in the world. First of all, all the salt water that covers over 70% of the earth's surface and surrounds its land masses is called "sea", or "the sea". But the sea actually consists of many seas of different sizes, for example the Black Sea, or the Caribbean Sea. The largest of the seas are called oceans, and there are seven of them, as listed above.

Actually, you can find other lists that define the seven seas differently. It doesn't really matter: the expression "the seven seas" is figurative, and is usually used to suggest "all the seas of the world", or everywhere that is covered by salt water.

28: Seven Proverbs

A **proverb** is a short, traditional saying in general use. It usually expresses some obvious truth or familiar experience. There are proverbs in all languages. Here are **seven proverbs that are well known** in English.

You can't tell a book by its cover.

We need to read a book to know if it's good or bad. We cannot know what it's like just by looking at the front or back cover. This proverb is applied to everything, not only books.

Where there's a will there's a way.

If we have the determination (the will) to do something, we can always find the path or method to do it.

Don't cross your bridges before you come to them.

Don't worry about problems before they arrive.

It was the last straw that broke the camel's back.

There is a limit to everything. We can load the camel with lots of straw, but finally it will be too much and the camel's back will break. And it is only a single straw that breaks its back - the last straw. This can be applied to many things in life. People often say "That's the last straw!" when they will not accept any more of something.

Bad news travels fast.

"Bad news" means news about "bad" things like accidents, death, illness etc. People tend to tell this type of news quickly. But "good news" (passing an exam, winning some money, getting a job etc) travels more slowly.

You can't take it with you when you die.

When we die we leave everything on earth. We don't take anything with us. Even the richest people cannot take their money with them after death. This proverb reminds us that some material things are not really so valuable as we think.

Still waters run deep.

Some rivers have rough surfaces with waves. That's usually because the water is shallow and there are rocks near the surface. But deep rivers have no rocks near the surface and the water is smooth and still. This proverb means that people who are calm and quiet on the outside, often have a strong, "deep" personality inside.

EnglishClub Wordchecker

straw (noun): dried stalk of grain; piece of dry grass

29: Seven Quotes

A **quote** or **quotation** is usually a short text—one or two sentences—spoken by one (usually famous) person and repeated or at least known by others. Every language has its famous quotations, and they range from highly amusing to deadly serious. Often they express a deep truth in a short, clever way—even the amusing ones.

Here are **seven of my favourite quotations**, arranged (very loosely) from humorous to serious. Have a look at them and try to understand them. Do you agree with them?

"It is a secret in the Oxford sense. You may tell it to only one person at a time." Oliver Franks (1905-92)

"The head cannot take in more than the seat can endure." Winston Churchill (1874-1965)—on the subject of long speeches

"Only the insane take themselves seriously." Max Beerbohm (1872-1956)

"To be uncertain is uncomfortable; but to be certain is ridiculous." Johann Wolfgang von Goethe (1749-1832)

"Say what you have to say in the fewest possible words." Arthur Bryant (1899-1985)

"Those who cannot remember the past are condemned to repeat it." George Santayana (1863-1952)

"When words lose their meaning, people lose their freedom." Confucius (551 BC - 479 BC)

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condemned (verb): sentenced as a punishment; forced to suffer

endure (verb): suffer patiently; tolerate

insane (adjective): seriously mentally ill

seat (noun): a person's buttocks

[More quotes by topic](#)

30: Seven Tips for Resumes

When you apply for a job, you are usually asked to send a CV or resume. This is a history of your education and work experience. Here are **seven tips for CVs and resumes** in English:

Tip 1: Use design that demands attention

Employers don't have time to read through each of your job descriptions to know if you have the skills they need. The design of your CV must do it for them. Your CV should be concise, well-organised and relevant. It should emphasise the most important and relevant points about your experience, skills and education.

Tip 2: Use "power words"

To control the image that an employer has of you, use power words that match the position you want. Certain words are used frequently by recruiters in their job descriptions. You should study recruiters' advertisements and job descriptions and use these words in your CV and covering letter.

Tip 3: A number is worth 1,000 words

Numbers are alive and powerful. They create images in our minds. General statements are easy to ignore. Be specific! Use numbers when describing your duties and achievements.

Tip 4: Put important information first

List important information at the beginning of your job descriptions. Put statements in your CV in order of importance, impressiveness and relevance to the job.

Tip 5: Sell benefits, not skills

Holiday companies don't sell holidays. They sell relaxation, adventure, sun, sea and sand (the benefits of a holiday). You should not sell your skills (many other people have the same skills). You should sell the benefits of your skills. When you write your skills and past duties, you can explain their benefits to the employer.

Tip 6: Solve the employer's (hidden) needs

Employers want people who can solve problems, not create them! Your CV and cover letter should show how you can solve the employer's problems and needs.

Tip 7: Target the job

You will have more success if you adjust your CV and cover letter for the specific skills an employer is seeking. This means that you would write one CV for one particular job and a different, modified, CV for another job.

31: Seven Sentence Stress Questions

Find the **stressed words in each sentence**. We are looking for neutral or normal sentence stress, not contrastive stress that we sometimes use to emphasize particular words in a sentence.

Example: My friend is English.

Answer: my FRIEND is ENGLISH

1. Do you like coffee?
2. Would you like a coffee?
3. I think he wants to go.
4. I don't think so.
5. London is the capital of Britain.
6. Have you ever seen this film?
7. Where can we go?

Answers overleaf

Answers to 26

1. do you LIKE COFFEE
2. would you LIKE a COFFEE
3. i THINK that he WANTS to GO
4. i DON'T THINK so
5. LONDON is the CAPITAL of BRITAIN
6. have you EVER SEEN this FILM
7. WHERE can we GO

32: Seven Extraterrestrial Planets

The planet Earth on which we live is part of the solar system. The Sun is a star at the centre of the solar system, and Earth and **the seven extraterrestrial planets** (and other bodies) revolve around it. Here are the planets of the solar system (including Earth), starting from the closest to the Sun.

Mercury—the fastest planet, named after the Roman messenger to the gods

Venus—the brightest planet, named after the Roman goddess of love and beauty

[Earth]

Mars—the red planet, named after the Roman god of war

Jupiter—the largest planet, named after the Roman king of the gods

Saturn—thought by the Romans to be the slowest planet, named after their god of time

Uranus—named after the Greek god of the sky and father to Saturn

Neptune—a deep sea-blue colour, named after the Roman god of the sea

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extraterrestrial (adjective): outside or beyond Earth

[More about the planets and their names](#)

33: Seven Eponyms

Many words in English come from a person's name. They have entered the English language so completely that they no longer take a capital letter. Such words are called eponyms. Here are **seven eponyms that we frequently use**.

casanova—a man who easily charms and seduces women (Giacomo Casanova [1725-1798] was an Italian author and adventurer with a reputation as a womanizer. He was interested in casual relationships, and wrote about his affairs with many women.)

hoover—vacuum cleaner; a machine for cleaning house interiors (William Henry Hoover [1849-1932] was an American businessman who founded The Hoover Company, making vacuum cleaners. The business expanded to Europe, where "hoover" became synonymous with vacuums and vacuuming.)

jumbo—something very large (In the late-1800s, a giant African elephant named Jumbo was transported to England and kept in the London Zoo. It was the largest elephant in captivity, and its popularity resulted in its name entering the English language.)

pasteurization—the exposure of food to very high temperatures in order to kill bacteria that can cause food to spoil (Louis Pasteur [1822-1895] was a French chemist who discovered that you could prolong the taste of beer and wine by heating it up and killing off the bacteria.)

sandwich—two slices of bread with some other food between them (John Montague [1718-1792], the 4th Earl of Sandwich in England, was a gambler who didn't like to leave the card table to eat. When he played cards he would place his lunch meat between two slices of bread to avoid getting greasy hands.)

volt—a standard unit of electromotive force (Alessandro Volta [1745-1827] was an Italian physicist who invented the first electrical battery, the "Voltaic pile", in 1799.)

wellingtons—knee-length waterproof boots made of rubber (Arthur Wellesley [1769-1852], the 1st Duke of Wellington in England, asked his shoemaker to redesign his military boots to be more comfortable. His new calfskin boots had no tassels and were cut without a strip at the top. After his defeat of Napoleon, "Wellington boots" became highly fashionable.)

[More about eponyms](#)

34: Seven Wonders of the Ancient World

A **wonder** is something beautiful or exceptional that gives us a feeling of surprise or admiration. **The Seven Wonders of the Ancient World** were amazing buildings and structures in distant history. Here is the generally accepted list:

1. **The Great Pyramid of Giza** (modern Egypt) - The Great Pyramid of Khufu (Cheops) at Giza, outside modern Cairo, is often called the first wonder of the world. This pyramid was built around the year 2560 BC and is the only Ancient Wonder to survive today.
2. **The Hanging Gardens of Babylon** (modern Iraq) - These beautiful gardens were probably built by King Nebuchadnezzar around the year 600 BC to please his queen, Amuhia. Their terraces perhaps rose as high as 300 feet.
3. **The Statue of Zeus** (Jupiter) at Olympia (modern Greece) - This was a colossal 40 ft high figure in gold and ivory. It was built by Phidias in the 5th century BC.
4. **The Temple of Artemis** (Diana) at Ephesus (modern Turkey) - This was a beautiful building, started about 350 BC, built in honour of the Greek goddess of hunting. The temple was destroyed by invading Goths in AD 262.
5. **The Mausoleum at Halicarnassus** (modern Turkey) - This was a famous tomb built by Queen Artemisia around the year 353 BC in memory of her husband, King Mausolus. This tomb is the origin of the modern word "mausoleum".
6. **The Colossus at Rhodes** (modern Greece) - This was a huge bronze statue of Helios (Apollo), about 105 ft high. It was created by the sculptor Chares, who apparently worked on it for 12 years, finally completing it in 280 BC. It was destroyed during an earthquake in 224 BC.
7. **The Pharos of Alexandria** (modern Egypt) - This was a lighthouse built by Sostratus of Cnidus during the 3rd century BC on the island of Pharos. It was destroyed by an earthquake in the 13th century.

35: Seven Interjections

Interjections are very common short exclamations like **oh!**, **well** or **ah**. They express feelings but have no grammatical value. We use them more in speaking than in writing. Here are **seven interjections that we use every day**.

ah

expresses...

pleasure: *Ah, that feels good.*

realization: *Ah, now I understand.*

resignation: *Ah well, it can't be helped.*

surprise: *Ah! I've won!*

er

expresses hesitation: *Lima is the capital of...er...Peru.*

hey

calls attention: *Hey! look at that!*

expresses surprise, joy etc: *Hey! What a good idea!*

hmm

expresses doubt: *Hmm. I'm not so sure.*

ouch

expresses pain: *Ouch! That hurts!*

uh-huh

expresses agreement: *Shall we go? / Uh-huh.*

well

expresses surprise: *Well I never!*

introduces a remark: *Well, what did he say?*

[Longer list of interjections](#)